BLR's Human Resources Training Presentations

Enhancing Professional Development of Employees

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Background for the Trainer:

- *Professional development of employees goes hand in hand with the growth and development of the organization and its success in achieving strategic goals.*
- *When employees are competent in their current jobs and are carefully prepared to fill critical higher-level jobs, the organization is better prepared to meet future challenges.*
- *Morale, productivity, and creativity are high in organizations that emphasize professional development at all levels.*
- *Professional development of employees is, therefore, an important management concern. Unfortunately, it's an area that often takes a back seat to many other pressing supervisory and managerial duties and day-to-day activities.*
- *The purpose of this session is to remind your supervisors and managers of this important responsibility and help them understand how they can carry it out successfully.*

Speaker's Notes:

- This training session will focus on your role in the professional development of employees.
- It is said that most people use less than 20 percent of their potential. Clearly, that's an unfortunate waste of opportunity. But on the job, this waste of talent has a negative impact on your department and the entire organization.
- By working with employees and encouraging them to grow and develop professionally, you can help them use more of their potential. This effort produces a multiple payback in which everyone benefits—your employees, the organization, and you.
- The professional development of employees is an important part of your job. During this session you'll learn many ways in which you can carry out this responsibility successfully.

Goals

- Recognize the importance of professional development
- Understand your role
- Be prepared to help your employees grow

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Speaker's Notes:

- We'll begin by talking about the importance of professional development to you, your employees, and the entire organization.
- Then, for most of the session, we'll focus on your role in the professional development process.
- We'll review with a case study that can help you see in a specific instance how a supervisor can assist an employee to grow and develop to his or her fullest potential.
- Finally, we will wrap up the training session with a summary and quiz.

Benefits of Professional Development of Employees

- Provides skilled, experienced, and motivated employees
- Promotes morale, productivity, and creativity
- Grooms employees for advancement
- Prepares the organization for the future
- Helps you attain your own professional goals

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Speaker's Notes:

Professional development is a win-win-win process. Everyone benefits—the organization, your employees, and you.

- Professional development provides the organization with more skilled, experienced, and motivated employees at all levels and in all departments.
- It promotes higher morale, productivity, and creativity in your department and throughout the organization.
- It grooms employees for advancement to fill vital positions in all key operations and functions, which benefits the organization and gives employees opportunities to get ahead, make more money, achieve greater status, and take on more challenging responsibilities.
- Professional development of employees also helps the organization prepare for the future. In order for the organization to grow and change to meet future challenges, its employees must also grow and change.
- Finally, it helps you, too. Obviously, developing employees keeps your department staffed with more skilled, experienced, and motivated workers. But it also allows you to make an important contribution to the future success of the organization. And that can have a positive impact on your own career development and the attainment of your own professional goals.

Three Categories of Employees

- Those who actively seek promotion
- Those who aren't sure where they want to go
- Those who are happy where they are

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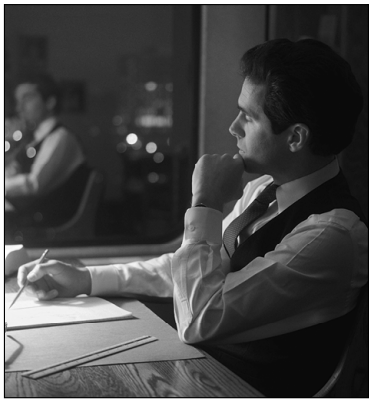
Speaker's Notes:

If you were to analyze your employees in terms of professional development ambitions, you'd probably find that you could divide them into three categories.

- One category is composed of those who actively seek promotion and know where they want to go. They may not know exactly how to get there, however, and that's where you can help.
- Then, there are those who aren't sure where they want to go. Often this group includes younger workers or those who are new on the job. These employees need advice, guidance, and help determining a realistic career path.
- Finally, there are those who are happy where they are. They are probably not interested in talking about advancement or career paths at this point. Nevertheless, they still need professional development. They must keep current with changes and need periodic training to remain competent in their jobs. And they may change their minds and decide that they do want to advance in the organization after all. If so, they will have a firm foundation on which to grow.

Professional Assessment

- Where is the employee now?
- Where does the employee want to go?
- Are the employee's aspirations realistic?



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Speaker's Notes:

In *The Wizard of Oz*, the good witch told Dorothy that if one wants to get anywhere, the best place to start is at the beginning. That's good advice for any journey, including the one we call professional development. For employees to progress, you have to start by helping them assess their current situation as well as their career aspirations.

- The first question to ask is, Where is this employee now? Current skills, experience, and knowledge are the springboard for future growth. Has the employee mastered the current job? If not, what must he or she begin with as a fundamental step on the road to career advancement?
- Next, employees have to consider where they want to go. There's usually more than one career path leading from each job. Which one is that employee's "yellow brick road," the path that will lead to his or her dreams? Encourage employees to think in the long range—at least five years into the future. Also, encourage them to think outside the box and look at nontraditional as well as traditional career paths. This may be especially important for female, minority, and disabled employees. The road to advancement may lead through areas traditionally dominated by able-bodied white men. Employees need to keep in mind that in the 21st century workplace, career opportunities are open to all who are willing to work to achieve them.
- Finally, when assessing career aspirations, you and your employees need to consider whether these ambitions are realistic. For example, an employee who lacks a college degree may have little chance of advancing into a coveted management position. That's not to say that the goal is impossible. The employee can go to school at night and earn a degree. But at the beginning, in the assessment process, you and your employees must take all realities into account. Then you can deal with them one by one.

Skills Inventory

- Technical skills
- Management skills
- Professional skills
- Personal skills

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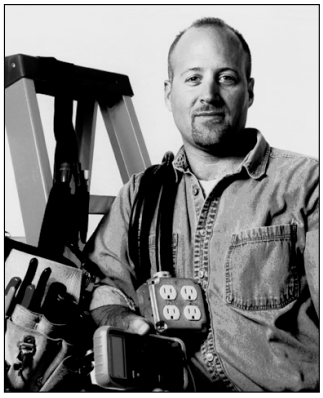
Speaker's Notes:

One of the best ways of taking all of the realities of an employee's current situation into account is to help the employee perform a skills inventory. The inventory will help you and the employee assess:

- Technical skills …
- Management skills …
- Professional skills …
- And personal skills. Let's look closer at each of these.

Skills Inventory: Technical Skills

- Mechanical skills
- Mental skills
- Knowledge of systems, methods, and procedures
- Problem-solving skills
- Other skills



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Background for the Trainer:

- *For the last point, other skills, you may wish to ask participants to talk about specific technical skills required for proficiency and advancement in their areas of expertise.*

Speaker's Notes:

Technical skills are an important part of most jobs and many career paths.

- Technical skills may include mechanical skills-for example, depending on the job, the ability to work manufacturing machines, computers, construction equipment, or electronic devices.
- They may also involve mental skills, such as the ability to work with numbers for someone in a financial field or the ability to work with words for someone in a communications field.
- In addition, technical skills include knowledge of systems, methods, and procedures. A warehouse worker, for example, needs to understand the inventory system, and a laboratory worker needs to understand testing methods and safety procedures.
- In all fields, employees must have problem-solving skills so that they can trouble-shoot effectively and anticipate potential difficulties on the job.
- Depending on the particular job and career path, an employee may also need other technical skills in a specific area of expertise. For example an HR specialist may need an understanding of employment laws and regulations, while someone in shipping may need knowledge of postal rules.

Skills Inventory: Management Skills

- Leadership
- Organization
- Communication
- Planning
- Training

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Speaker's Notes:

For many employees, professional development will eventually mean moving up to supervisory and management positions. That means they will need additional skills.

- As you well know, they will need leadership skills to direct and motivate their employees.
- Certainly, they will need organizational skills. They will have to know how to coordinate employee activities, delegate tasks, and manage their own time.
- Supervisors and managers also need excellent communication skills, which include speaking, writing, and listening.
- And they must be able to plan well. Effectively managing workflow, budgets, and projects requires good planning skills.
- Finally, all supervisors and many managers must be skilled trainers. They need to be able to teach employees effectively everyday to promote productivity, quality, and safety in their departments.

Skills Inventory: Professional Skills

- Human relations
- Negotiation
- Cooperation
- Presentation

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Speaker's Notes:

Employees who wish to advance in many careers also need to develop their professional skills.

- Professional skills include human relations skills—the ability to work well with people and bring out the best in others.
- Likewise, the ability to negotiate effectively is a useful professional skill at any level, but it is particularly necessary the higher a person rises in an organization.
- Cooperation is another essential professional skill. Being able to collaborate with other managers and supervisors and work as a member of the management team is a basic professional skill in any line of work.
- Presentation is also an important professional skill. Presentation encompasses a person's ability to present himself or herself in a professional manner and fit into the organizational culture, while maintaining individuality and integrity.

Skills Inventory: Personal Skills

- Responsibility
- Judgment
- Initiative
- Creativity
- Follow-through

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Speaker's Notes:

The final category in the skills inventory is personal skills.

- This category includes skills such as responsibility and reliability.
- It also involves good judgment.
- And, of course, no one gets ahead without the ability to take initiative. That means exhibiting drive, energy, and self-motivation to develop professionally.
- Creativity is another important skill in most jobs and career paths. Being perceptive and imaginative is a skill that will become more and more in demand in many jobs as we progress into the 21st century.
- Follow-through is also an invaluable skill that must be cultivated during the professional development process. Follow-through includes perseverance and the ability to see plans and projects through to successful completion. It involves assuring quality and getting results.

Review of Work History

- Greatest achievements
- Defining moments
- Pluses and minuses of jobs to date
- Preferred talents

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Speaker's Notes:

After assisting an employee complete a skills inventory, it's a good idea to review work history. Suggest that the employee look back over his or her work history, from the very beginning, and consider accomplishments as well as other significant aspects of his or her work experience.

- For example, employees should look at their greatest work-related achievements to date. These may be achievements made in the current job or in earlier jobs.
- What defining moments have employees had in their career? A defining moment is a turning point, a point at which the employee's career path took a turn that led to his or her current job and professional aspirations.
- Employees should also look at what they have liked most and least about their jobs to date. This can help direct future development in the direction of work that involves greater job satisfaction.
- In addition, employees should consider the talents they enjoy using most. Most people have many talents that they use in their work. By emphasizing the talents they enjoy using most, employees can find greater satisfaction in their work and achieve greater success in their careers.

Goals and Goal Setting

- Criteria for professional development goals
- Long-term goals
- Intermediate goals
- Short-term goals
- Action plans

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Speaker's Notes:

With this important background work done, you and your employees can shift focus from the past and the prese to the future, which is what professional development is all about for most employees. And the future is about goals and goal setting.

- All professional development goals must meet four basic criteria. Employees must understand that goals need to be reasonable, attainable, relevant, and challenging. Reasonable means realistic and practical. Attainable means possible to achieve given the circumstances. Relevant means they must be directly connected to the employee's career aspirations. And challenging means that they must motivate the employee to move forward at a steady pace without being so difficult that they lead to frustration and stagnation.
- In addition, employees must understand that there are three categories of goals. Long-term goals focus far into the future. Long-term goals are most often framed in terms of years. An employee's long-term goal might be to head up a department or advance to top management.
- Intermediate goals are usually framed in terms of months or years. They form a bridge between long-term goals and short-term goals. For example, a major step in the direction of an employee's long-term goals might be a promotion to a position with some supervisory responsibility.
- Short-term goals are framed in terms of days, weeks, or months. They lead to intermediate goals, which in turn lead to long-term goals. For example, a short-term goal of managing a project could lead to an intermediate goal of gaining supervisory responsibilities. That, in turn, could lead to the long-term goal of heading up a department.
- Finally, employees must realize that every career goal must be linked to an action plan for achieving it. Without an action plan, a goal remains a dream.

Making Effective Use of the Performance Appraisal Process

- Encourage employee input
- Set performance goals consistent with developmental goals
- Add to skills inventory
- Keep employees focused and on track

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Speaker's Notes:

One of the most effective supervisory tools for professional development of employees is the performance appraisal process.

- You should encourage employee input during the performance review meeting to learn more about your employees' professional aspirations.
- Together you can fashion a set of performance goals that not only meets the needs of your department but also supports each employee's plans for professional development.
- In this way, employees can gain the skills they need to perform their current job better as well as skills they need for promotion.
- Regular performance appraisals also give you the opportunity to guide employee development and help keep your workers focused and on track toward their professional goals.

Offering Appropriate Training Opportunities

- Group training
- One-on-one training
- Coaching
- Cross-training

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Speaker's Notes:

Skills needed for personal and organizational growth change constantly. That means offering appropriate training opportunities is a key professional development tool.

- Group training can not only provide employees with the essential skills they need to perform well in their current jobs but also prepare them for promotion.
- One-on-one training can narrow the focus to include specific skills an employee needs to advance along his or her particular career path. You can provide the training yourself when you have time, or delegate this task to experienced employees. This can also be accomplished by sending the employee off-site to a seminar or a conference workshop.
- Coaching is another excellent way to develop employees on a one-to-one basis. This informal, often spontaneous, daily contact with employees offers many opportunities to focus on professional development. It lets you guide and direct a worker's progress. It gives you an on-the-spot opportunity to recognize accomplishments and build on them. And it provides a chance to motivate and support employees in their self-development efforts.
- Cross-training is another productive way to build new skills and provide new work experiences. Cross-training also broadens an employee's perspective, allowing the worker to see how what others do fits in with what he or she does. An understanding of the bigger picture is essential as employees rise to higher levels in the organization.

Leadership Training

- Doing vs. leading
- Organizational skills
- People skills
- Communication skills

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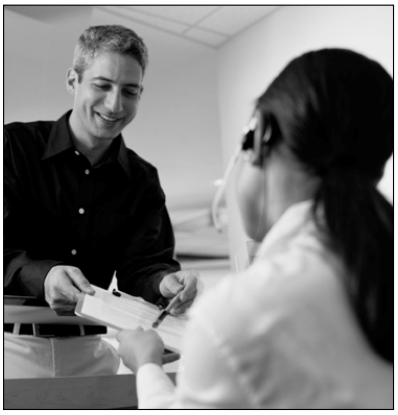
Speaker's Notes:

In addition to training in job skills and essential knowledge, many employees on a promotion track need leadership training to prepare them for supervisory and managerial positions.

- The first thing employees need to learn about leadership is that leading isn't doing. Getting others to perform a job as desired is quite different from doing the job yourself. So the first step in leadership training is to make this difference clear and to teach an essential leadership skill that we'll discuss in a moment—delegation.
- Leaders must also be well organized in order to manage the work of a group.
- They need good people skills so that they can handle all kinds of people effectively.
- And they must be able to communicate effectively so that their directions and guidance are clearly understood.

Teaching Delegation

- Determine the task
- Define the task
- Select the right person
- Explain the task
- Provide support and feedback
- Follow up



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Speaker's Notes:

Delegation is an essential managerial skill. Employees who aspire to leadership positions must begin to acquire this skill now. Teaching delegation means providing opportunities to practice the skill—perhaps through management of a special project or team effort. It also means imparting an understanding that delegation is a six-step process.

- When you delegate, you must first determine which tasks to delegate. Some work only you can do, but other work can be done just as well by an employee, freeing you up to do more of the work only you can do.
- Then you need to define the task. Specifically, what needs to be done, step by step?
- Next, you must select the right person to do the job. You may want to refer back to your employees' skills inventories to identify which employees are best suited to which tasks.
- Then you have to explain the task completely to the employee and answer questions.
- Once the employee begins the task, you need to provide support and positive feedback to ensure success.
- And finally, you must follow up to make sure that the task has been performed completely and accurately.

Other Educational Opportunities

- Higher education
- Seminars and conferences
- Workshops and self-instructional materials

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Background for the Trainer:

- *This would be a good time to discuss programs that support continuing education, such as tuition reimbursement.*
- *You may also wish to review your organization's policy, procedures, and budgeting for sending employees to professional seminars.*

Speaker's Notes:

Workplace training is a key ingredient of professional development. But it is not the only educational experience available to your employees.

- Employees who wish to advance in the organization can make themselves more promotable by enhancing their credentials. For example, they can get higher degrees and certifications by taking courses at local institutions or online.
- Seminars and conferences also offer educational opportunities. Whenever you have the chance to send employees to these events, you are helping them develop professionally.
- Employees may also grow and develop by working on their own through workshops, self-instructional materials, and other continuing education opportunities to develop skills and knowledge that can help them advance their careers.

Hands-on Experience

- Daily work
- Special projects
- Teams
- Outside experience

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Background for the Trainer:

- *If your organization sponsors any community events or supports any community organizations, such as softball teams or Special Olympics, this would be a good opportunity to discuss how to get involved in these activities.*

Speaker's Notes:

You can also help your employees develop through a variety of hands-on experiences.

- By introducing new tasks and creating challenges whenever possible, you can use daily work as an effective means of professional development.
- Special projects are ideal development tools because they bring so many managerial and functional skills into play.
- Teamwork is also an excellent way to help employees develop professionally. Cross-functional or organization-wide teams, such as safety committees, are especially useful because they introduce employees to people and activities in other parts of the organization. And as we've said before, this broader view is essential for employees who want to advance into management positions.
- In addition to workplace experiences, you and your employees should never forget the importance of outside experiences. For example, an employee can gain much valuable organizational and leadership experience as a volunteer for a community event, as a fundraiser for a charitable organization, or even as the coach of a local little league team.

Feedback

- Reinforce the positive
- Correct the negative
- Provide specific examples
- Develop plan to turn feedback into positive action
- Follow up and provide additional feedback as necessary

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Speaker's Notes:

Providing positive feedback is a fundamental part of any manager's or supervisor's job. It is also a key element in professional development of employees.

- Feedback reinforces positive behavior and motivates employees to perform at their best.
- It also helps you correct mistakes and improve poor performance. Constructive feedback identifies what was done poorly and describes the action or behavior necessary to correct the problem and improve performance.
- When you give feedback, be sure to provide specific examples. For instance, you might say to an employee, "You covered all the points well during your presentation, but you didn't give others the chance to ask questions." Or "You did a great job running the meeting. All the agenda topics were covered, and everyone had a chance to participate."
- Make sure that feedback is linked to an action plan. For example, you might say, "You've done a great job keeping the project on schedule. To make sure you meet the final deadline, it would be a good idea to ask the other members of the team for daily updates from now on."
- Feedback about professional development is never complete without follow up to make sure the employee continues to progress toward his or her goals. Often, additional feedback will be required to keep employees on track and motivated.

Motivation

- Provide challenging job assignments
- Instill a sense of mission
- Focus on strengths
- Recognize and reward accomplishments

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Speaker's Notes:

We've already talked quite a bit about motivation. But since motivation is an important part of helping employees with professional development, we should make a few additional points.

- One of the most powerful motivators at a manager's or supervisor's disposal is providing employees with challenging job assignments. Well-supported challenges encourage employees to perform at their best and strive to attain goals.
- You can also motivate employees to stick to professional development efforts by instilling in them a sense of mission. Remind them frequently of their career goals.
- Another effective motivational technique is to focus on strengths rather than weaknesses. You can help employees correct weaknesses through training and work experiences. But by focusing on their strengths, you help them develop self-confidence and build self-esteem, both of which are necessary for a person to grow and develop.
- Finally, motivating employees to achieve career goals requires recognition of their accomplishments and appropriate rewards. Recognition may be in the form of a pat on the back or a letter of commendation. Rewards may be in the form of additional growth opportunities or advancement another step closer to their desired goal.

Informal Guidance

- Provide support
- Serve as a role model
- Make introductions
- Supply information

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Speaker's Notes:

Most of what we've been talking about throughout this session involves formal actions you take as a manager or supervisor to encourage employees' professional development. But in many cases you can also act informally as a mentor.

- You can provide continuing support to keep employees going over the long haul.
- You can also serve as a role model—as someone who has succeeded in doing exactly what the employee would like to do.
- In addition, you can help promote the interests of qualified employees by making sure they meet the right people in the organization.
- And you can make a point of seeing that they have the information they need to keep up-to-date with what's going on in the organization and the industry.

Keep Employees Informed About Opportunities for Advancement

- Within their department
- Other departments
- Other branches/divisions

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Background for the Trainer:

- *If your organization has no other branches or divisions, eliminate the third point from the frame and the Speaker's Notes.*
- *If your company has a central location for job announcements, be sure to mention it during this slide.*

Speaker's Notes:

Let's face it: There is a potential downside to professional development from your point of view. If you make an effort to develop your employees, sooner or later you're going to lose them. It's kind of like raising children well. You help them to become strong, competent, independent adults, and they leave you. But as long as the employees you've helped stay with organization, everyone benefits. Which brings us to our final point. It's a very simple and practical one. If you want your employees to grow, develop, and advance in the organization, you need to keep them informed about opportunities for advancement.

- Make sure they know about promotional opportunities in your department …
- In other departments …
- And even in other branches or divisions of the organization.

Case Study: Going Nowhere Fast

- Employee Issues:
  - Seems to lack ambition
  - Unsure of opportunities
  - Uncertain about goals
  - Not aware of talents
  - Lacks confidence in abilities

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Background for the Trainer:

- *If time allows, you may wish to get participants to suggest the actions the supervisor should take before proceeding to the next frame and providing them with the suggested answers.*

Speaker's Notes:

Now I'm going to read you a short case study. It's titled "Going Nowhere Fast." It's about a supervisor who is trying to decide how best to help an employee with professional development. I want you to think about the situation as I read it, because afterwards I'm going to ask you to decide what the supervisor in this case should do.

- Employee Joe Smith is a hard worker and does a good job but seems to lack ambition. Joe has been on the job for a little over a year. His supervisor, Jane Jones, believes that he has a bright future with the company, and she wants to prepare him for advancement.
- However, when Jane talks with Joe about his future with the company and the possibility of advancement, Joe seems unsure of the opportunities that might be open to him.
- Furthermore, he is uncertain about his professional goals. When Jane asks him where he sees himself in five years, Joe says he really hasn't thought about it.
- When Jane asks him to name his five greatest skills, Joe can only name two.
- After talking to Joe for a while, Jane comes to see that he also lacks confidence in his own abilities. Although he is performing very well, he seems to think his work is "just ok."

Case Study: Comment

- Make employee aware of opportunities
- Work with employee on goals and goal setting
- Perform a skills inventory with employee
- Provide positive feedback, encouragement, and support

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Speaker's Notes:

What steps should this supervisor take to help this employee develop professionally? There are at least four actions you can take in a case like this.

- Number one, make the employee aware of opportunities for advancement within the department and the organization. Often, employees would like to get ahead, but they just don't know what the prospects are.
- Number two, work with the employee on identifying and setting goals. If the employee has no vision of where he wants to go, he's unlikely to get there.
- Number three, perform a thorough skills inventory with the employee so that he is aware of his talents and abilities.
- And number four, provide positive feedback, encouragement, and support to build self-esteem and self-confidence and to keep the employee motivated and moving in the right direction.

Goals

- Recognize the importance of professional development of employees.
- Understand your role in the professional development process.
- Be prepared to help your employees grow and develop to their fullest potential.

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Speaker's Notes:

- Here is a recap of the material we've covered today.
- Are there any questions concerning your role in the professional development of your employees?
- Let's wrap up this training session with a summary and a quiz.

Summary

- Professional development presents a win-win situation
- Morale, productivity, and creativity are increased
- As a supervisor, you play an important role in your employees' professional development

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Background for the Trainer:

- *Recap the points made here to the extent you feel it is necessary.*

Quiz

1. A basic step in professional development involves creating a _____ inventory.
2. It is difficult or impossible for employees to achieve career goals without an_____ _____.
3. Employees who have no interest in promotion don't need to bother with professional development. **True or False**
4. Since professional development looks at the long term, employees only need to determine long-term goals to achieve their career objectives. **True or False**

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Background for the Trainer:

- *Remind participants that the quiz is to encourage further discussion and to ensure that everyone understands what was discussed.*

Quiz (cont.)

5. In addition to training in job skills, in most cases, employees also need training in _____ and _____ skills to advance to higher level jobs.
6. Name the four parts of a skills inventory.
7. You can use the performance appraisal process effectively to help employees work toward their career goals. **True or False**
8. Volunteer work in the community can often assist in an employee's professional development. **True or False**

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Quiz (cont.)

9. Name three ways you can motivate employees to pursue professional goals.

10. You should keep employees informed about opportunities for advancement even if that eventually means losing them to another part of the organization. **True or False**

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Quiz Answers

1. A basic step in professional development involves a skills inventory.
2. It is difficult or impossible to achieve goals without an action plan.
3. False. Professional development is for all employees, even those who are happy in their present jobs. They still need to keep current and competent. And who knows, some day they may change their minds and seek advancement.

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Quiz Answers (cont.)

4. False. Employees need to set short-term and intermediate goals as well in order to achieve long-term goals.
5. Employees who aspire to management positions also need training in leadership and delegation skills.
6. The four parts of a skills inventory are technical skills, management skills, professional skills, and personal skills.
7. True.

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Quiz Answers (cont.)

8. True.
9. You can motivate employees to pursue professional goals by providing challenging job assignments, instilling a sense of mission, focusing on strengths, and recognizing and rewarding accomplishments.
10. True.

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